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FINDING GOD IN A DISTANT LAND

BY A CHRISTIAN

Second Chapter

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Media vlogger presents

A NARROW PATH

BY A CHRISTIAN

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A Note from the Author:

You may wonder why this story is shared under a pseudonym 'a Christian' or 'Curtis'. In a world that often demands a face and a name for every story, I have chosen to remain in private (for now unless the Lord asks me to do otherwise). This decision is born out of prudence and a deep respect for the privacy and integrity of the people who have walked it with me.

By remaining anonymous, I hope that my personal identity fades so that the message of faith, the beauty of the culture that has welcomed me, and the grace that has sustained my family can shine more clearly. This is not just my story; it is a testimony of a path paved by a higher hand, the hand of our Lord Jesus Christ.

All visual assets represent the author's artistic vision, serving as a cinematic bridge between technology and storytelling. However, **all the story and events narrated here**, come from the deepest part of the hearth of a brother in Christ (me) who went through this events and was guided by the holy spirit of God to share this story with the world.

About this free version:

Thanks for downloading a Narrow Path Second Chapter! You can read this part of our testimony and appreciate the illustrations from **chapter number two**, in this chapter I share the beginning of our journey and all the hindrances that I experienced at my first workplace in the East, how the news of a disease in China back at that time changed all my plans and how my world ended upside down. **God bless you all!**

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PRE FACE:

The Map of a Restless Heart

Hi, you can call me “Curtis”. I never intended to write a book, mostly because I never intended to be the man I am today. For a long time, I lived my life as if it were a series of disconnected rooms: the room of my childhood in the West, the room of my religious fundamentalism, the fortress of my fierce atheism, the neon-lit, labyrinth of China, and finally the return to the Lord’s path.

If you are holding these pages, it’s likely because you’ve also felt that strange, hollow ache of being an outsider — not just in a foreign country, but in your own skin, maybe even in your workplace or your house. This is a testimony, I hope that God somehow may speak to you through this book, and even though it may include some recommendations, this is not a manual on how to "survive" China as a Christian, nor is it a theological treatise designed to convince you of anything. It is not written to criticize any authority nor to do anything illegal, just my personal story and honestly, I’m still figuring things out with God’s guidance to see where does he take our starting ministry.

This is simply a raw, honest map of how I lost my way, how I tried to build a life out of logic and self-help books, and how I eventually ran out of gas in the middle of crisis in the 2020's, how I met people and bumped into, love, disappointment and joy, how some people ended up being a very important part of my life and how the Lord by his grace and love, started to restore everything I had lost as a result of my own decisions, how also he miraculously started to manifest in ways I never expected to those that I met along the way, things that to this day I do not have any reasonable explanation . And how the quiet, persistence of a mother's faith is something I never expected would have such a great impact in my life.

Living in the east has been a mirror. It is a place that requires efficiency over emotion and results over rhetoric. It stripped me of my masks and left me standing in a quiet apartment looking at myself, surrounded by fences, health codes, and colorful apps forced to look at the wreckage of my own heart.

I've tried to outrun a God I claimed didn't exist, but slowly manifested during my struggles. I am writing this for the dreamers, for the skeptics who are afraid of being

manipulated, and for anyone who has ever felt like they were dragging a heavy stone uphill without knowing why. I want to tell you that wherever you are, there is hope even in the silence of a lockdown, in the sharp edges of the corporate world of any country.

whether it is China or not, God cares about you and he can restore everything you can imagine even in the edges of ashes and depression.

This is my story—unfiltered, a bit "corny" at times, and definitely stubborn. It's the story of a man who went to the other side of the world to be successful, only to find himself in front of God in a place he thought he would never find him, but even if you try to hide; he will find you anywhere, by reading this you will realize that some of my memories weren't just nostalgia—they were echoes of a truth I was trying to ignore and oh my—this may touch some nerves or emotions.

Welcome to my journey. Let's walk through these rooms together.

CHAPTER 2: The Breaking Point and the Silent Wall

Before we move forward, I want to **clarify** that some descriptions in the second chapter **may feel blunt, raw or harsh**. So dear reader, my intention is to authentically convey the stress and challenges I faced during the first part of my journey in China. These observations reflect my personal state of mind at that time and are **not intended to generalize** an entire culture or its people. My goal is to share my story with honesty, **not to cause offense**. Thank you for walking this path with me and for reading this through the lens of a brother in Christ.

CHAPTER 2:

The Weight of the Western and Eastern World

Now that you have some cultural context I will share with you my story and testimony and how these changes by the grace of God despite my difficulties, have helped me grow.

I have felt a connection with the East since childhood. My parents had lived in the west for many years but they had many things from China, one of my favorites was a collection of old Chinese movies from the 80s and 90s, and I would spend hours watching them—sometimes with my father, laughing together at Jackie Chan’s films. My father would always tell me curious facts about the lives of those celebrities, which sparked a fascination for the East. As I grew up, there was a mixture of cultures in my mind; I felt that the East was a part of me that just happened to be on the other side of the world. At that time, I was content with movies and often anime. Even though anime is from Japan—China’s ‘enemy’—you would be surprised by how many young Chinese people also truly love Japanese anime culture.

I grew up in what many would call a "normal" home, though looking back, I realize that "normal" is often just a convenient mask for a very specific kind of chaos. My childhood was shaped by the typical friction of a marriage under pressure, but it was my father's alcoholism that truly defined our early landscape at the beginning. It was a heavy cloud that sat over our living room for years. When my mother, exhausted by the cycle of drink and despair, finally found her way to a Christian church and received Christ, the foundation of our house shifted.

She spent months on the verge of leaving him, a suitcase of "what-ifs" always packed in her mind, she usually vented some of her feelings to my grandma. I would hear her on the phone but I used to pretend I didn't listen to those conversations for months, but when she received Christ in those days after attending a Christian church she was invited to, not only she did change but I saw hope and determination in her eyes, something I haven't seen before, she finally convinced my father to walk through the church doors after telling him she would leave with us if he continued such a path; so then, he changed, he looked persuaded by my mother's determination and then, the miracle happened!



Christ helped dad! and it was a real change, I saw others succumb to alcohol again, but not my father. In my teenage eyes, it was grand. We were finally at peace. No more shouting, just the quiet, predictable principles of a church. At first, I followed those rules because they promised a safety I had never known.

The Stages of Insecurity

But inside, a different storm was brewing. I was a reserved kid, a dreamer who watched life through a glass wall, feeling everything but saying very little. I noticed how Western culture rewards the expressive—those who can talk their way into any heart.

In the church, the people on the worship stage were the stars; they were admired, almost radiant.

Regarding our spiritual area after my parents' conversion, my father had been a musician since childhood and influenced my mother to become a singer. When we became Christians, it was natural for us to put these gifts at the service of the church. They were often hired for events, ministers' birthdays, and weddings; consequently, their work took them to many different churches rather than just one. However, I wanted to establish myself in a single church to see if I could truly develop my own talents.

I'll be honest, and it's not pretty: my reasons for joining the music ministry weren't "holy." I was an insecure teenager with low emotional intelligence, craving the admiration of others to fill a void I didn't yet understand. I wanted to be "up there" so people would finally see me. It sounds reticulated and small, I know, but it was my reality.

Serving God became a performance to fix my own broken self-esteem, I know, it began for the wrong reasons. I started attending a small church near my home. I remember that day clearly; my parents were going

to a large church that was too far from where we lived, so I decided to explore the area and found this smaller one nearby. I was only about fourteen years old, but I was excited and didn't mind the size of the place.



That Sunday morning, the minister quickly noticed me

since it was such a tight-knit community.

'I want to welcome the newcomers,' he said while preaching. I raised my hand and was welcomed like a family member, I felt accepted. From then on, I joined that community to serve. At that humble altar, I learned about Gospel music, worship, ministry, and leadership. It became my starting platform.

The Fundamentalist Cocoon and The Rebellion

Because I struggled to express my feelings, I embraced religion like a suit of armor. I became a fundamentalist—a rigid, judgmental version of myself. It was a toxic cocktail: a quiet kid who didn't know how to face the world, backed by a "righteous" checklist that allowed me to look down on others and judge mercilessly.

Eventually, the hormones and the natural curiosity of youth began to claw at that armor. I wanted to experience what every other teenager was living—the messy world of dating, the thrill of a first glance, the human connection that lies outside of "thou shalt not."

I felt repressed and, frankly, bitter. I would ask myself: "If I'm such a 'good man,' why am I the one sitting alone while the 'sinners' are happy?" or that's what I thought, the reason? I didn't understand many things back in the day, so back to the story, after some years at church and at the age of 18 or 19 I turned to self-help books to fix my social awkwardness and to improve my "dating skills", but their "hacks" only left me more fractured. I tried to implement some changes with the teenage girls at church, I had seen some responsiveness from them, so I thought that being a "bad boy" was the ultimate solution, that previous resentment I had for the church soon curdled into a deep hatred for religion. I blamed God for my loneliness because I saw that these "solutions" were coming from self-help books and not from Him. I saw the church as a machine of oppression, and I decided to burn that bridge and walk away, I wanted more.

Leaving the church was not nice either, I was one of the leaders singing at the small altar, I also remember that afternoon, I went upstairs to the pastor's office and after some years of accumulated frustration I finally let out all my feelings, (God bless that man for his patience with a brat like me in those days); he somehow saw that coming, because little by little he noticed

my changes in attitude and behavior and he wanted to ask why I was thinking only about dating, *“there is more for you coming from God than that”* said the minister, but those wise words fell on deaf ears. Next to him there was a woman who was the mother of one of my friends, I remember her eyes full of tears as if she was my mother, saying, please don’t go that way, it moved me a little bit, but I didn’t listen, I was determined to walk away and do my thing, all I could say to her was, “I’m sorry” before leaving.



The Iron Fortress of Atheism

University was my “Awakening”. After a couple of failed attempts, I finally got in, and the world of secular ideologies felt like pure oxygen. I dived headfirst

into a fierce, uncompromising atheism. I wanted to be like those "free" people—expressive, wild, and uninhibited. But my upbringing and my naturally reserved nature had left a permanent mark. I was trying to be a lion when I was still, at heart, a quiet observer.



Even when I tried to follow the "modern" path of quick fixes and shallow pleasures, my inner self rebelled. Deep down, I was still "corny." I wanted the very things the self-help books and modern world told me were weaknesses: real love, a stable family, a meaningful connection. I spent years lying to myself, wearing a mask of "gratification" while my soul was starving for substance. It took years of toxic interactions at university

and emotional exhaustion to realize that I had just swapped one form of repression for another. This happened because the relationships I developed with friends or partners, were established with a fake version of myself, which at the end caused conflict, so after this many failed relationships I felt that a very “powerful” part of myself died again, in a matter of days I isolated myself in my world one more time just as that insecure teenager, but this time, it was not out of peace, it was to protect my hurting wounds. Had I known this before, I would have chased more sublime or productive goals during those years. For example, financial goals, self-development goals etc.

Even though I rebelled against God, He protected me from many dangerous situations during that time. Even while I was partying, drinking, or disobeying my parents, my relationship with them remained good. To be honest, they tolerated too many of my antics. My mother was a constant reminder of the right path, but I shrugged her off several times. I noticed that I influenced my family negatively back then.

During my final semesters, I finally tried to make some changes so my parents would have a son who finished college.

It was an uphill battle but I managed to graduate. The hardships I lived through taught me a lot; unfortunately, it seems there was no other way for me to learn those lessons, but just by falling down and standing up again.



After some years at university and living ups and downs “on my terms” My "atheism" was still firm in those days though. I thought that the merit of my achievements was only mine, sometimes forgetting about my family’s prayers and support to help me. Before graduation, all the financing that I got was from them (yeah they were angels and I wasn’t seeing the whole thing at that time).

The High-Tech Labyrinth

I had worked in the west for some months one year after graduation, I had gotten good feedback from my colleagues, but I didn't want to save money for something stable in the west, I didn't want to stay there, even if the atmosphere at this workplace was quite good, I had dreams, I wanted more, maybe to travel to the East. That feeling was inside of me for a long time, so I remember one day during a family meeting that my mom wanted to show me the online profile of an advisor who was selecting candidates to go to China, even in the area I was working in, so I thought, "this is for me!".

After two days I asked my mom about this guy again and I contacted him, it was through his Facebook profile and the guy looked and sounded professional, when I sent him a message for the first time he said he would help me with everything to get a job there if I passed all the filters, but also told me that it may take some months. And as if it was some sort of a "prophetic" word, this process indeed took around 6 months. To not bore you with details in which nothing relevant happened it was a jungle of online tests, paperwork, contracts, photos, Facebook messages, video calls, permits etc.

I managed to pass all the filters and when the opportunity came, it felt like a cosmic reset. I didn't get into bad habits too much after I received my acceptance letter, not because I didn't want to celebrate, but because I didn't have the time to drink or party while preparing for my trip, my parents noticed that I was taking the new opportunity seriously and saw this as a sign of maturity and supported my journey to "find what I had lost." I was expecting to find people like me—reserved, quiet, maybe a bit more "internal." I had no idea I was walking into a furnace.

Two weeks before boarding the plane, I had several meetings with my family.



We had gone to my childhood places together so we could remember those last days for a long time.

We had profound talks on tops of hills in my favorite parks, went hiking, took pictures, and ate my favorite western food, I talked to mom, dad and my siblings about everything, it was a mixture of feelings because I didn't know when I was going to see them again, but at the same time there were high expectations on my part. But those two weeks went by in the blink of an eye, the day to leave the west finally came.

The Farewell

My parents took me to the airport by car and they looked enthusiastic, talking about trivial stuff and how advanced China should be now compared to twenty years ago, after one hour we got to the airport and my mom said one thing before I left, trust in God. But for me it was just normal words she would say in situations like this so I didn't pay attention to them and I hugged each one of them for about 10 seconds, my father and my siblings looked like holding tears but genuinely happy for me.

When I turned my back waving good bye, the moment finally came, I was on my own and went through the customs area with nervousness, the officers noticed it, but I told them that it was one of my first times flying so far from home by myself

(funny! I was acting as if trying to let them now that I didn't have a bomb in my luggage) when I boarded that plane, I looked back at the west for the last time.

After many exhausting hours and many queues at customs I arrived in a city of neon and high-pressure, marveling at the robots in the airport and the seamless, biometric data systems. But the "welcome" was cold and professional. People here didn't want your life story; they wanted your efficiency. But I just wanted to rest that day.



I had high hopes that China would finally define my future. And it would indeed, but not the way I expected.

The Mask of the Advisor

Then came the red flags. The advisor who brought me over—who played the role of the "bridge-builder" —

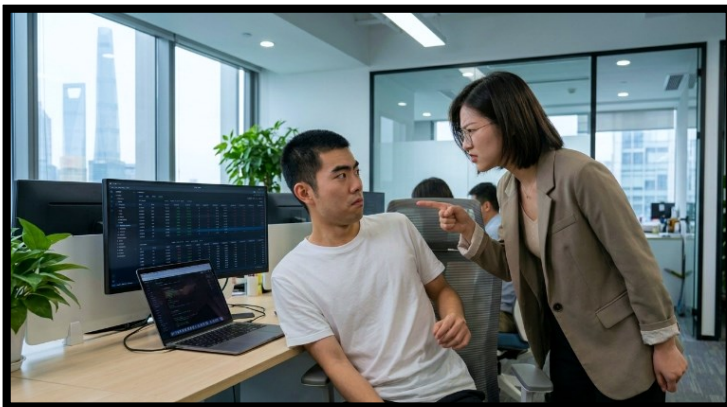
turned out to be a master of omission. As soon as I landed, he took me to my place in his car, I noticed that his kindness also implied unexpected demands. After two days of logistics and accommodation, He suddenly became sharp, demanding, and sometimes capricious with his feedback. Some things he asked for when practicing with him were not mentioned during the filters. So I stood my ground, threatening to turn back and cancel everything, and he retreated—I think it was because I was his ticket to a large commission. But I didn't want to give up, "*things need time*" I thought.



The Archetype of the Storm

Then I met my boss. In these hyper-competitive Chinese cities, I found an archetype: the woman in her 40s, sharp-voiced, cold, compact in size, chubby and highly driven by the bottom line. (*Remember pls, this is **not** to generalize*).

She was the personification of the machine. No "good morning," no "how are you." Just orders, money, and text messages that hit your phone like commands from a general. If you showed weakness, she would eat you alive. So friends, brace yourselves; this is the blunt part I warned you about: Some of these aunties look almost the same, talk and walk similarly, is a personality type that you will instantly recognize in China, with time and a trained eye you develop this skill and can recognize these aunties from miles away with all the package: hasty, pushy, bossy, loud and cold. When I used to see one with that "appearance", I said to myself: - "here she comes, one of those aunties" and boom! she started talking and acting exactly the way I imagined, they are scattered in some industries in china as if they were manufactured in the same assembly line. Remember again, **it is not everyone**. Now, let's meet a younger version of an auntie.



Have you ever met the personification of evil? Well... Let me introduce Veronica, a nerdy looking woman obsessed with power and control, Don't be deceived by her delicate figure and small-triangle like face. After I met her and shook hands on my second day of work I thought it was going to be a friendly colleague, but Oh my...! How wrong I was, every instruction or message from her lips was a cold mandate, delivered without a hint of human warmth. "Do this. Change that. Not a "please", not a "thank you", it lasted for days. I felt like I had made the biggest mistake of my life. I remember regretting my decision every time I hear her annoying voice after days of efforts that seemed useless, it looks like there was one problem on top of another for her, one night, in a mix of pure rage and total frustration. I asked myself "Is this all there is to China?" I wondered. I saw other newcomers, whether foreigners or American Chinese becoming hard, cold, and even a few of them a bit aggressive just to survive, setting firm boundaries like soldiers defending a trench.

Note: By the grace of God and by the day I am writing this, the place where I am working at is respectful and friendly and honestly I got so familiar with the work flow here that I can even work on my projects and ministries

step by step to serve God properly, and it will be the platform for me to take off in the future and no, no one is aiming at me with a gun to say this, ha-ha.

However, I hope to become completely independent from the corporate system and as I said before, not all places are the same in a single country, but I learned throughout this experience to detect toxic patterns.

Back to our story the level of competition in these companies can drive you to the edge of madness. It strips you of your tranquility and turns your coworkers into sharks in a small tank. I tried to ask for a bit of formality to my "friend" Veronica (in the bad workplace I was at first), a bit of basic respect. It lasted two days. After that, the coldness returned. Without the peace of God in my heart and with no calm to get in that restless ocean of pressure, I eventually stopped trying to be the "good guy." I started answering back with the same fire that was burning me, becoming a version of myself I didn't recognize, but the only one that seemed to survive in the dark path.

During those days I was dating someone, and the problem was that I didn't know which relationships were healthy and which ones not because I was still not mature

enough, so of course, the pattern of toxic relationships was still being present in my life, but shortly after, the world as we knew was about to change and it was about to affect every relationship I had in those days anyways. I also carried some of my problems at work into my relationship, I was trying to tell my date what I was going through and I noticed that this also affected her a lot, I reached a point where I didn't even want to show up at that workplace anymore. I missed the professionalism and warmth I experienced in the West—that feeling of being treated like a human being and a professional, with a sense of calm.

Back in that workplace I started to react, and not in the best way. My heart lost its peace, and honestly, that just drained my energy, even Veronica looked shocked one day after I answered back to her about an arbitrary feedback she gave me, but this was toxic and exhausting.

But again, I've learned not to generalize. It's not that all Western companies are "good" and all Chinese companies are "bad." It's about the environment, the toxicity (or lack of it) from the bosses, and, ultimately, where God wants you to be. I kept pushing, trying to give my best and show results, but in China, the mindset of a boss or colleagues with the mindset of Veronica or

the “evil auntie” may be sometimes like a shifting tide—unpredictable. They might smile at you while something else is brewing under the surface, all just to “keep the harmony” and avoid direct conflict. It sounds strange, I know, but that’s the reality of the labyrinth here.

There were controversies about a new disease that was spreading out and at that moment I thought it was just another piece of ordinary news.

Days later, and feeling more adapted to the workflow I said to myself “I think I can do this”, but days after I received a call by the supervisor that brought me here in the first place and I was let go. I was taken to the boss office and she in a cold and calm manner told me I was doing a “good job”, but that I lacked “love and passion.” But, hey! Even if I didn’t love the place, I was putting a lot of effort, and to be honest, some colleagues didn’t look too enthusiastic when going there either; some of them had several misconducts, so I was in denial, the opportunity cost me a big financial and emotional investment, that news felt like a punch in the gut. The good side though, was that probably I wouldn’t miss Veronica; also the advisor had to help me because he needed me to get some income to get a commission.

The Disease

Suddenly, after some news, me and millions of people at that time found ourselves in a surreal landscape. I remember waking up to see people in full hazmat suits—white figures moving like ghosts through the streets. At first, I thought it was just a routine check with some lights on the streets, but then, during the second day after I brushed my teeth and wanted to get something from the supermarket the fences came. Overnight, metal walls went up, and I was completely isolated with the partner I had back in the day.



During those dark days, my mother was my anchor. She would call me on WeChat, her voice full of a faith that I, in my atheism at the time, didn't quite share.

"Trust in God," she would say. She said she prayed constantly for me, but I didn't care, I wanted to hear the voice of someone familiar to me.

In the middle of that chaos, I started an online business to survive, I thought it was interesting, but I wasn't expecting the response I got online. Slowly, I began to see what she was talking about. Even as my world was shrinking to the size of an apartment, something was starting to shift inside me.

Some others were losing their jobs in China and being able to sustain myself without any company felt like a personal victory, people needed to consume some products because the panic buy was on top.

The Cracks in the Foundation

The pressure of the lockdown wasn't just physical; it was emotional. I was living with someone at the time, and the confinement turned our home into a pressure cooker. We fought. Hard. It wasn't my proudest moment—I was too expressive, too frustrated, and I let my weakness show.

As the sirens blared outside and people panicked-bought

everything in the supermarkets, our relationship hit a wall. We couldn't stand each other anymore. Even with some financial help, the atmosphere was toxic. She decided to leave for another province, but in a country where your every move is tracked by a digital code, even saying goodbye becomes a bureaucratic nightmare. I stood there, looking at the fences and the empty streets, realizing that I was stripped of everything I thought I controlled.

"I used to think that the worst thing in life was to end up all alone. It's not. The worst thing in life is ending up with people who make you feel all alone"

Robin Williams.

As the days bled into weeks, the apartment ceased to be a home and became a mirror—one that reflected everything I had been trying to ignore. Outside, the silence of the city was unnatural, broken only by the occasional announcement from a loudspeaker or the distant clatter of supplies being delivered. Inside, the silence was even louder. I was trapped in a space where the air felt thick with everything left unsaid.

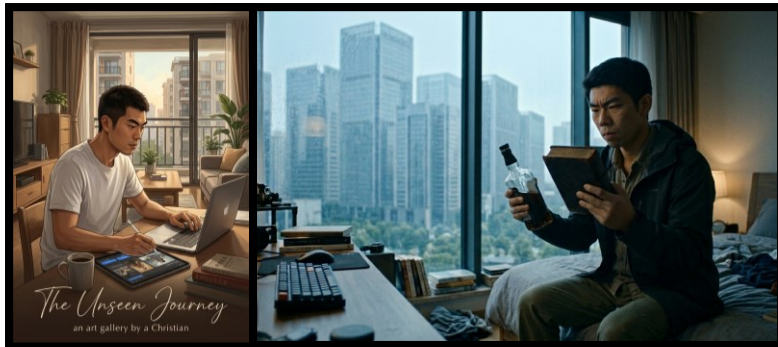
My relationship wasn't just ending; it was dissolving under the weight of the walls closing in.

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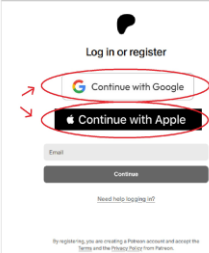
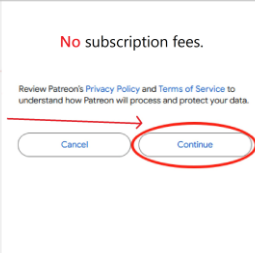
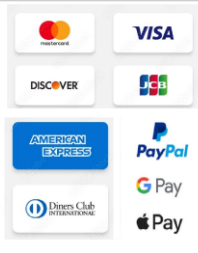


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